Ten Minutes Left

France was down 2-0 with ten minutes left when I decided the match was over.

The broadcast clock kept moving almost politely. In my room on the North China Plain, winter air pressed against the window. Argentina seemed ten minutes away from lifting the World Cup. Their passes had begun to feel less like attempts to create something than a way of letting the remaining minutes expire. Every completed sequence shortened the future.

I had already begun turning what I had watched into a finished story. Argentina had been better. France had arrived at the last page too late to revise anything. I was no longer watching to find out what would happen; I was watching the ending I had already written reach the screen.

Then the game broke its own rhythm.

A foul, a penalty, a restart, a turnover, a lofted pass, a volley: Kylian Mbappé scored twice in under two minutes. The second goal happened so quickly after the first that the match seemed not to have caught up with itself. One moment France was trying to make the score respectable. The next, the score was 2-2 and every interpretation I had made ten minutes earlier had become unusable.

France would later fall behind in extra time, equalize again, and lose on penalties. Before France's first goal, none of that future was available to the players—or to me.

A league season allows recurrence. Lose on Sunday and there is another match, another month, another chance for form to return. The World Cup arrives once every four years and compresses an athlete's prime into a handful of nights. One mistimed tackle, one fracture of luck, one body aging at the wrong point in the cycle, and four irretrievable years are gone. Football has a clock everyone can see and a future no one can.

At 2-0, France did not need an abstract belief in possibility. They needed someone to make the next run before the possibility disappeared. The clock was not symbolic to the players. It was removing actual opportunities one second at a time.

Years behind a drum kit gave me another way to think about timing.

When I first learned to play against a metronome, I treated the click as a judge: either the stick landed with it or it did not. Software could make the judgment even more exact, snapping a note onto a vertical grid line and calling the correction progress.

Sitting behind a kit made that idea harder to keep.

The grid is not the enemy of groove, but obedience to the grid is not rhythm either. A drummer can sit a fraction behind the beat, pull the pulse backward, then place the next strike where the other musicians need it. Push too far and the groove collapses. Pull back too little and nothing happens.

A hand delays. The band keeps moving. For an instant the note seems to be in danger of missing the place where it belongs. Then it lands, and the delay becomes part of the rhythm instead of a failure of it.

Snap every note to the grid and the result may be correct yet dead.

Isolate a displaced strike on a recording and it looks late. Put the bass line back in and its place becomes intelligible. The strike has not moved. Only what surrounds it has changed.

Hearing a recording, I already know that the bass arrives, that the next snare lands, that the hesitation resolves instead of collapsing the passage. Playing it, none of that future is available. The stick comes down before the next beat has happened.

What looks inevitable on a waveform may have felt precarious in the body.

Football has the same asymmetry.

An attacker does not move through a replay. The defender reads an expected beat—the next touch, the planting of a foot, the moment acceleration should begin. Bodies announce what they are about to do: weight shifts, hips turn, a stride lengthens.

Then an attacker pauses for half a beat. The defender's weight commits to the expected future. The attacker leaves through the space that expectation has opened.

I do not need to claim that a civilization lives inside that movement. It is enough to watch one body make time briefly elastic.

Still, matches like this tempt me into myth.

Watching football across countries, I start finding patterns everywhere. Germany becomes machinery; Brazil, improvisation. The Dutch, after

centuries of holding back the sea, seem destined to treat every boundary on the pitch as provisional.

The stories click into place with the satisfaction of a solved equation.

Too much satisfaction, probably.

A country is not a tactical formation. Reclaimed land did not cause Total Football, and war is not a training method. I had taken things separated by decades, institutions, people, accidents, and choices, and compressed them until a pattern began to look like a cause.

A story can illuminate something without explaining it. The danger begins when its elegance makes me forget how much has been left outside the frame.

When I learned that Luka Modrić grew up displaced by war, playing in the car park of the Zadar hotel where his family had been housed after fleeing their home, the narrative assembled itself almost before I noticed I was assembling it.

The thin boy against history. The body overturning the sentence of fate.

Modrić controls the tempo of a match; his childhood had been violently interrupted. It is not difficult to make those two facts rhyme.

The footballer who would eventually control time in midfield because time had once been taken from him.

It is also too complete.

War did not manufacture his vision. His career cannot redeem what happened to him, and suffering does not owe the future a beautiful

explanation. The conditions of his childhood exerted force without exhausting what he could become.

Once I know where a life goes, earlier events begin to rearrange themselves. What survived looks like preparation. What mattered later looks destined to matter from the beginning. The possibilities that led nowhere quietly leave the story.

Replay does something similar to a football match. Watch Mbappé's first penalty now and it already belongs to a comeback. The run before it becomes the beginning of something. The turnover before the second goal looks charged with consequence. Even the clock seems dramatic because I know what it is counting toward.

At 2-0, those events belonged to no such structure. They were only attempts.

I recognize the same habit closer to home.

After leaving conventional schooling, I told myself a clean version of my own story: I had refused a predetermined perimeter and found open ground. It sounded good partly because it used the grammar of football—a boundary, an escape, space appearing in front of me.

The truer version was less cinematic. There were exam dates I could not move, schedules I designed carefully and sometimes failed to follow, and hours lost before I found the right question. There were afternoons when freedom felt less like open ground than an empty document. No teacher assigned the next chapter. No bell divided one failed hour from the next useful one.

If I followed the wrong question, nothing outside me necessarily announced it. If something took three times longer than I had planned, the schedule did not defend itself. It simply stopped being true.

Sometimes I mistook having no imposed structure for having found the right one. I could make a week look convincing before living it. On paper the pieces fit: mathematics here, physics there, a project pushed forward between them. But a plan seen from Sunday night contains a future that Wednesday morning does not. One problem opens another. Something I thought was finished stops being finished. A day acquires a shape I could not have assigned to it in advance.

No bell told me whether I had begun on time. Freedom often looked like blank space I had to fill without knowing whether I was using it well.

That made the heroic version harder to maintain. Leaving school did not release me from constraint; it made some constraints less visible and some choices more obviously mine.

But I also do not want to replace one clean story with another. It would be convenient to say that uncertainty itself became the lesson, that I learned to embrace unfinished things, that every wrong question proved useful in the end.

Some were simply wrong questions.

Some time was simply lost.

Not every failed schedule later revealed itself as necessary preparation for a better one. Sometimes the future does not redeem the past. Sometimes an error remains an error even after I have found a way forward.

So I cannot honestly say that football proves determination wins.

Most teams trailing 2-0 lose. Bodies tire. Careers end. A defender reaches the ball first. A shot hits the post. The whistle arrives. France equalized twice and still lost.

If I turn those ten minutes into a lesson that persistence guarantees reversal, I make the same mistake I made with countries, with Modrić, and with my own schooling.

I am making some version of it now, writing this after the final whistle, already knowing how the story ends.

But at 2-0, the conclusion did not exist yet.

The rebellion matters because it is temporary, and because it may fail.

Before Mbappé's first goal, the French players did not know they were inside a comeback that would later be replayed around the world. They knew only the next run, the next press, the next patch of grass that had to be reached before the clock removed it.

Watching afterward, we arrange those minutes into a story. Living them, they had no such luxury.

That is why the run made at 2-0 stays with me more than the equalizer. It came before the story could organize itself, when the future had become very small.

By the time the broadcast ended, fine dust outside had not moved in hours. France had lost. Their refusal had not changed the champion; it had changed the ten minutes I had already dismissed.

The whistle comes eventually. Until it does, the body has not agreed.